

The Masque of the Red Death

Edgar Allan Poe · 1842

First published: Graham's Magazine, May 1842

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Masque_of_the_Red_Death (revision 14967671), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 8–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Masque of the Red Death suggest about the inevitability of death?
- What does The Masque of the Red Death suggest about privilege and isolation?
- What does The Masque of the Red Death suggest about time?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Masque of the Red Death	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*the inevitability of death* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Masque of the Red Death

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

Poe wrote the story in 1842, the year his wife Virginia first coughed blood from tuberculosis, a disease that killed many in his family. Cholera epidemics had swept American cities in 1832. The plot, a prince sealing himself away from plague, recalls Boccaccio's Decameron and older traditions of the "dance of death."

Publication and reception, then and now

First published as "The Mask of the Red Death: A Fantasy" in Graham's Magazine (Philadelphia) in May 1842; retitled "The Masque" in 1845.

Then: Little notice at publication.

Now: It is read as an allegory of death that no wealth can wall out, and gained new attention during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Overview (spoiler-free)

While a plague called the Red Death kills half the land, Prince Prospero and a thousand courtiers lock themselves in a fortified abbey for a lavish masked ball in seven strangely coloured rooms.

Main themes

- the inevitability of death: no wall keeps it out.
- privilege and isolation: the rich abandon the poor.
- time: the ebony clock interrupts every pleasure.

Why it matters

The story asks what the powerful owe others during a crisis, a question students lived through in 2020.

Spoilers · teacher only

At midnight a masked figure dressed as a Red Death corpse appears; Prospero pursues it and dies, and the guests discover the costume is empty; the Red Death claims them all.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Masque of the Red Death: If a disaster struck, would people with money be safe? Should they try to be?
Prompt: Before we open The Masque of the Red Death: If a disaster struck, would people with money be safe? Should they try to be?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

allegory; symbol; masque (a masked ball); setting as symbol; personification.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. Poe wrote the story in 1842, the year his wife Virginia first coughed blood from tuberculosis, a disease that killed many in his family. Cholera epidemics had swept American cities in 1832. The plot, a prince sealing himself away from plague, recalls Boccaccio's Decameron and older traditions of the "dance of death." Publication and reception. First published as "The Mask of the Red Death: A Fantasy" in Graham's Magazine (Philadelphia) in May 1842; retitled "The Masque" in 1845. Then: Little notice at publication. Now: It is read as an allegory of death that no wealth can wall out, and gained new attention during the COVID-19 pandemic.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“The external world could take care of itself” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2). Prospero's attitude toward the dying outside.

> *The external world could take care of itself (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2)*

Think-aloud: “The external world could take care of itself” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2). Prospero's attitude toward the dying outside.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): While a plague called the Red Death kills half the land, Prince Prospero and a thousand courtiers lock themselves in a fortified abbey for a lavish masked ball in seven strangely coloured rooms. Themes to track: the inevitability of death: no wall keeps it out. privilege and isolation: the rich abandon the poor. time: the ebony clock interrupts every pleasure.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Masque of the Red Death: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Masque of the Red Death still matter? The story asks what the powerful owe others during a crisis, a question students lived through in 2020.
Anchor question: Why might The Masque of the Red Death still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story asks what the powerful owe others during a crisis, a question students lived through in 2020.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

What does the ebony clock represent, and why does everyone stop when it chimes? Answer: Time and mortality; even the revellers cannot ignore that time is passing toward death.
Exit ticket: What does the ebony clock represent, and why does everyone stop when it chimes?
Answer: Time and mortality; even the revellers cannot ignore that time is passing toward death.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Masque of the Red Death.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Masque of the Red Death" (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/masquea.htm)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The connection to Virginia's illness is biographical inference; Poe never said so.

Lesson 2: The Masque of the Red Death

Focus: the futile attempt to shut out death

Objective: Students will analyze how symbolism develops in "The Masque of the Red Death" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (plague deaths): Sensitive content: Plague deaths. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes plague deaths.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

While a plague called the Red Death kills a third of his realm, Prince Prospero walls himself and a thousand nobles inside a fortified abbey. He throws a masked ball in seven colored rooms running east to west, the last black with blood-red windows and a great ebony clock. At midnight a guest disguised as a Red Death corpse appears; Prospero chases him into the black room and dies, and the revelers find the costume empty. The Red Death has entered, and all die.

Background: Poe wrote it in 1842, in a century of cholera epidemics; his wife Virginia was showing signs of tuberculosis that year.

Significance: It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to privilege and isolation because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes plague deaths.
Prompt: Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to privilege and isolation because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: bedewed — wet with drops, as of dew or tears; dabbled — dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid; bizarre — conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual; seizure — capture; being taken by force; maddening — driving one wild. "bedewed": From Middle English bidewen, bideawen; equivalent to be + dew. Cognate with Dutch bedauwen "to bedew", German betauen "to bedew".
Words: bedewed: wet with drops, as of dew or tears · dabbled: dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid · bizarre: conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual · seizure: capture; being taken by force · maddening: driving one wild

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Poe wrote it in 1842, in a century of cholera epidemics; his wife Virginia was showing signs of tuberculosis that year. It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar. Symbolism: Seven rooms running east to west (blue to black) are often read as the stages of life; the last, black with blood-red windows, contains the clock. Setting: The sealed abbey with welded gates is a world of artificial pleasure built to deny death. Imagery: Colour and light (stained glass lit by braziers) and the clock's chime dominate the senses. Watch for the ebony clock: time and death; each hour the dancers freeze.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "The external world could take care of itself" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2). Prospero's indifference. That is symbolism at work: Seven rooms running east to west (blue to black) are often read as the stages of life; the last, black with blood-red windows, contains the clock.

> *The external world could take care of itself (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "The external world could take care of itself" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2). Prospero's indifference. That is symbolism at work: Seven rooms running east to west (blue to black) are often read as the stages of life; the last, black with blood-red windows, contains the clock.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Personification and capital letters make Darkness, Decay and the Red Death rulers: the true kings. Ask: How does this line connect to privilege and isolation? Expected: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. (The final sentence: personified triumph.)

> *And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Personification and capital letters make Darkness, Decay and the Red Death rulers: the true kings.
Ask: How does this line connect to privilege and isolation?
Expected answer: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. (The final sentence: personified triumph.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for symbolism, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the futile attempt to shut out death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Masque of the Red Death develops the idea of the futile attempt to shut out death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. When the text says "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14), it shows this directly. Prospero declares that "the external world could take care of itself," but the clock forces even his musicians "to pause ... to harken to the sound," and the final sentence gives "the Red Death" "illimitable dominion over all."
Task: Annotate the story for symbolism, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about the futile attempt to shut out death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Masque of the Red Death develops the idea of the futile attempt to shut out death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. When the text says "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14), it shows this directly. Prospero declares that "the external world could take care of itself," but the clock forces even his musicians "to pause ... to harken to the sound," and the final sentence gives "the Red Death" "illimitable dominion over all."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it? Ask students to argue for one interpretation of the seven rooms with text evidence.
Anchor question: Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it?
Facilitation: Ask students to argue for one interpretation of the seven rooms with text evidence.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the futile attempt to shut out death? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. ("And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all", The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about the futile attempt to shut out death? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. ("And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all", The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how symbolism shapes the futile attempt to shut out death. Key takeaway: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Symbolism:** Seven rooms running east to west (blue to black) are often read as the stages of life; the last, black with blood-red windows, contains the clock.
- **Setting:** The sealed abbey with welded gates is a world of artificial pleasure built to deny death.
- **Imagery:** Colour and light (stained glass lit by braziers) and the clock's chime dominate the senses.

Themes and how they develop

- **privilege and isolation:** Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed.

Symbols and motifs

- **the ebony clock:** time and death; each hour the dancers freeze.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "The external world could take care of itself" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2) Prospero's indifference.
- "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14) The final sentence: personified triumph.
- "the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5) The clock's power.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death.
Evidence: "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14)
Reasoning: Prospero declares that "the external world could take care of itself," but the clock forces even his musicians "to pause ... to harken to the sound," and the final sentence gives "the Red Death" "illimitable dominion over all."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
bedewed (verb)	wet with drops, as of dew or tears	*And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.*	"bedewed": From Middle English bidewen, bideawen; equivalent to be + dew. Cognate with Dutch bedauwen "to bedew", German betauen "to bedew". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/bedew#Etymology)
dabbled (verb)	dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid	*His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.*	
bizarre (adjective)	conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual	*Here the case was very different; as might have been expected from the duke's love of the bizarre.*	
seizure (noun)	capture; being taken by force	*And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.*	
maddening (adjective)	driving one wild	*It was then, however, that the Prince Prospero, maddening with rage and the shame of his own momentary cowardice, rushed hurriedly through the six chambers, while none*	

		followed him on account of a deadly terror that had seized upon all.	
profuse (adjective)	produced or growing in extreme abundance	*There were sharp pains, and sudden dizziness, and then profuse bleeding at the pores, with dissolution.*	"profuse": From Latin profusus. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/profuse#Etymology)
windings (noun)	the act of winding or twisting	*To the right and left, in the middle of each wall, a tall and narrow Gothic window looked out upon a closed corridor which pursued the windings of the suite.*	
quieted (verb)	calmed	*And then the music ceased, as I have told; and the evolutions of the waltzers were quieted; and there was an uneasy cessation of all things as before.*	
cessation (noun)	a stopping	*And then the music ceased, as I have told; and the evolutions of the waltzers were quieted; and there was an uneasy cessation of all things as before.*	"cessation": Borrowed from Middle French cessation, itself a borrowing from Latin cessātiō. By surface analysis, cease + -ation. Compare cession < cede. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cessation#Etymology)
decorum (noun)	propriety in manners and conduct	*In truth the masquerade license of the night was nearly unlimited; but the figure in question had out-Heroded Herod, and gone beyond the bounds of even the prince's indefinite decorum.*	

Discussion questions

1. Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the inevitability of death?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Prince Prospero do when the plague strikes? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey
2. How many rooms are in the imperial suite? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Seven
3. What object in the black room makes the dancers pause each hour? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A gigantic ebony clock
4. How is the mysterious guest disguised? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: As a corpse marked by the Red Death
5. What do the revelers find when they seize the stranger? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The mask and shroud are empty
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Masque of the Red Death" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: While a plague called the Red Death kills a third of his realm, Prince Prospero walls himself and a thousand nobles inside a fortified abbey. He throws a masked ball in seven colored rooms running east to west, the last black with blood-red windows and a great ebony clock. At midnight a guest disguised as a Red Death corpse appears; Prospero chases him into the black room and dies, and the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Masque of the Red Death"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Masque of the Red Death" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall." What does "bedewed" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: bedewed: wet with drops, as of dew or tears.
10. Reread: "His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror." What does "dabbled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: dabbled: dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Masque of the Red Death" suggest about the futile attempt to shut out death? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar.
2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about the futile attempt to shut out death? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: "The external world could take care of itself" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2): Prospero's indifference. On setting: The sealed abbey with welded

gates is a world of artificial pleasure built to deny death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “The “Red Death””, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Masque of the Red Death”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: While a plague called the Red Death kills a third of his realm, Prince Prospero walls himself and a thousand nobles inside a fortified abbey. He throws a masked ball in seven colored rooms running east to west, the last black with blood-red windows and a great ebony clock. At midnight a guest…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Masque of the Red Death” set up that the rest of The Masque of the Red Death will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14): The final sentence: personified triumph. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5): The clock's power. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Why do people sometimes try to ignore a danger instead of facing it?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the inevitability of death? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “The external world could take care of itself” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2): Prospero's indifference. On imagery: Colour and light (stained glass lit by braziers) and the clock's chime dominate the senses. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Poe wrote it in 1842, in a century of cholera epidemics; his wife Virginia was showing signs of tuberculosis that year. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held

illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14): The final sentence: personified triumph. On setting: The sealed abbey with welded gates is a world of artificial pleasure built to deny death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "It is read as an allegory: the rooms as stages of life, the clock as time, the stranger as death no wealth can bar." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: "the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5): The clock's power. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: "The external world could take care of itself" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2): Prospero's indifference. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Masque of the Red Death" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the futile attempt to shut out death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14): The final sentence: personified triumph. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Masque of the Red Death": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: "the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5): The clock's power. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to privilege and isolation: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “The external world could take care of itself” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2): Prospero's indifference. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14): The final sentence: personified triumph. On symbolism: Seven rooms running east to west (blue to black) are often read as the stages of life; the last, black with blood-red windows, contains the clock. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Masque of the Red Death” treats the futile attempt to shut out death with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Masque of the Red Death see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5): The clock's power. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the inevitability of death? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “The external world could take care of itself” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2): Prospero's indifference. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the futile attempt to shut out death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14): The final sentence: personified triumph. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth

cannot protect anyone from death. Useful evidence: “the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5): The clock's power. Theme link: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “To the right and left, in the middle of each wall, a tall and narrow Gothic window looked out upon a closed corridor which pursued the _____ of the suite.” Word bank: bizarre, bedewed, windings, dabbled

   Key: windings
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the revelers find when they seize the stranger?

   A. He is a doctor

   B. The mask and shroud are empty

   C. He is the prince's brother

   D. He is a thief

   Key: B (The mask and shroud are empty)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2: “The _____ world could take care of itself”

   Key: external
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5: “the musicians of the orchestra were _____ to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound”

   Key: constrained
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14: “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held _____ dominion over all”

   Key: illimitable
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How is the mysterious guest disguised?

   A. As a corpse marked by the Red Death

   B. As the prince

   C. As a jester

   D. As a monk

   Key: A (As a corpse marked by the Red Death)
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Prince Prospero do when the plague strikes?

   A. He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey

   B. He burns the villages

C. He flees to another country

D. He nurses the sick

Key: A (He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How many rooms are in the imperial suite?

   A. One

   B. Seven

   C. Twelve

   D. Three

   Key: B (Seven)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "And then the music ceased, as I have told; and the evolutions of the waltzers were _____; and there was an uneasy cessation of all things as before." Word bank: bedewed, quieted, dabbled, bizarre

   Key: quieted

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "There were sharp pains, and sudden dizziness, and then _____ bleeding at the pores, with dissolution." Word bank: bedewed, profuse, bizarre, dabbled

    Key: profuse

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "The external world could take care of itself" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Prospero's indifference.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Masque of the Red Death"?

    A. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

    B. The futile attempt to shut out death

    C. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    D. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

    Key: B (The futile attempt to shut out death)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The final sentence: personified triumph.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "The Masque of the Red Death"? Seven rooms running east to west (blue to black) are often read as the stages of life; the last, black with blood-red windows, contains the clock.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Allusion

    C. Symbolism

    D. Point of view

    Key: C (Symbolism)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in "The Masque of the Red Death"? The sealed abbey with welded gates is a world of artificial pleasure built to deny death.

    A. Setting

B. Diction / vocabulary

C. Simile

D. Point of view

Key: A (Setting)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how privilege and isolation develops from an earlier story to “The Masque of the Red Death”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “It was then, however, that the Prince Prospero, _____ with rage and the shame of his own momentary cowardice, rushed hurriedly through the six chambers, while none followed him on account of a deadly terror that had seized upon all.”
    Word bank: bizarre, dabbled, maddening, bedewed
    Key: maddening

18. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What object in the black room makes the dancers pause each hour?

    A. A gigantic ebony clock

    B. A fountain

    C. A bell tower

    D. An organ

    Key: A (A gigantic ebony clock)

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The clock's power.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The external world could take care of itself” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Prospero's indifference.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14).
    Sample answer: Prospero declares that "the external world could take care of itself," but the clock forces even his musicians "to pause ... to harken to the sound," and the final sentence gives "the Red Death" "illimitable dominion over all."

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Prospero declares that "the external world could take care of itself," but the clock forces even his musicians "to pause ... to harken to the sound," and the final sentence gives "the Red Death" "illimitable dominion over all."

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Here the case was very different; as might have been expected from the duke's love of the bizarre.”, what does “bizarre” most nearly mean?

    A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    C. capture; being taken by force

D. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

Key: B (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual)

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The final sentence: personified triumph.

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.", what does "dabbled" most nearly mean?

    A. capture; being taken by force

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    C. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

    D. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    Key: C (dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.", what does "seizure" most nearly mean?

    A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    C. capture; being taken by force

    D. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

    Key: C (capture; being taken by force)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.", what does "bedewed" most nearly mean?

    A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    B. capture; being taken by force

    C. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    D. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

    Key: A (wet with drops, as of dew or tears)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 8, 17, 2, 6, 3, 10, 18, 4, 11, 13, 12, 19, 14, 15, 20	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	9, 1, 4, 2, 18, 3, 5, 8, 11, 13, 12, 14, 19, 15, 20, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 1, 9, 4, 2, 3, 18, 13, 12, 11, 21, 19, 14, 15, 16, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	17, 2, 5, 6, 9, 8, 13, 12, 11, 21, 19, 14, 15, 16, 22, 20	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	17, 23, 1, 7, 8, 12, 13, 11, 14, 15, 19, 21, 16, 24, 20, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 6, 5, 17, 1, 13, 11, 12, 14, 21, 19, 15, 20, 22, 16, 24	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	17, 2, 6, 4, 25, 13, 11, 12, 19, 21, 14, 15, 22, 16, 24, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	6, 5, 9, 8, 26, 12, 13, 11, 14, 19, 15, 21, 20, 16, 24, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Senior	3, 17, 27, 26, 6, 11, 12, 13, 15, 19, 21, 14, 22, 20, 16, 24	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	18, 2, 4, 5, 1, 13, 11, 12, 15, 21, 19, 14, 22, 24, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Masque of the Red Death,” how does Poe show the futile attempt to shut out death? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In The Masque of the Red Death, how does Poe develop the idea of the futile attempt to shut out death? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Masque of the Red Death develops the idea of the futile attempt to shut out death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of the futile attempt to shut out death. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Masque of the Red Death suggests about the futile attempt to shut out death. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses symbolism in The Masque of the Red Death to complicate the reader's understanding of the futile attempt to shut out death. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Situate The Masque of the Red Death within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the futile attempt to shut out death responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Read The Masque of the Red Death alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the futile attempt to shut out death follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Masque of the Red Death and its treatment

of the futile attempt to shut out death. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop a research argument that reads The Masque of the Red Death as evidence for a larger claim about the futile attempt to shut out death in The Masque of the Red Death. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop an original argument that reads The Masque of the Red Death as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the futile attempt to shut out death. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Masque of the Red Death.

SAT-style questions

1. *Here the case was very different; as might have been expected from the duke's love of the bizarre.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “bizarre” most nearly mean?

   A. a stopping

   B. propriety in manners and conduct

   C. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

   D. calmed

2. *The “Red Death” had long devastated the country. No pestilence had ever been so fatal, or so hideous. Blood was its Avator and its seal—the redness and the horror of blood. There were sharp pains, and sudden dizziness, and then profuse bleeding at the pores, with dissolution. The scarlet stains upon the body and especially upon the face of the victim, were the pest ban which shut him out from the aid and from the sympathy of his fellow-men. And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Masque of the Red Death”?

   A. Superstition used against a credulous man

   B. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

   C. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

   D. The futile attempt to shut out death

SAT key: 1. C (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual); 2. D (The futile attempt to shut out death)

Unit test

The Masque of the Red Death: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “There were sharp pains, and sudden dizziness, and then _____ bleeding at the pores, with dissolution.” Word bank: bedewed, profuse, bizarre, dabbled
   Key: profuse
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How is the mysterious guest disguised?
   A. As a corpse marked by the Red Death
   B. As the prince
   C. As a jester
   D. As a monk

   Key: A (As a corpse marked by the Red Death)
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Prince Prospero do when the plague strikes?
   A. He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey
   B. He burns the villages
   C. He flees to another country
   D. He nurses the sick

   Key: A (He shuts himself and a thousand nobles in an abbey)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How many rooms are in the imperial suite?
   A. One
   B. Seven
   C. Twelve
   D. Three

   Key: B (Seven)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5: “the musicians of the orchestra were _____ to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound”
   Key: constrained
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “It was then, however, that the Prince Prospero, _____ with rage and the shame of his own momentary cowardice, rushed hurriedly

through the six chambers, while none followed him on account of a deadly terror that had seized upon all." Word bank: bizarre, dabbled, maddening, bedewed

Key: maddening

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "To the right and left, in the middle of each wall, a tall and narrow Gothic window looked out upon a closed corridor which pursued the _____ of the suite." Word bank: bizarre, bedewed, windings, dabbled

   Key: windings

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2: "The _____ world could take care of itself"

   Key: external

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "And then the music ceased, as I have told; and the evolutions of the waltzers were _____; and there was an uneasy cessation of all things as before." Word bank: bedewed, quieted, dabbled, bizarre

   Key: quieted

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What object in the black room makes the dancers pause each hour?

    A. A gigantic ebony clock

    B. A fountain

    C. A bell tower

    D. An organ

    Key: A (A gigantic ebony clock)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What do the revelers find when they seize the stranger?

    A. He is a doctor

    B. The mask and shroud are empty

    C. He is the prince's brother

    D. He is a thief

    Key: B (The mask and shroud are empty)

12. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14: "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held _____ dominion over all"

    Key: illimitable

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Masque of the Red Death"?

    A. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

    B. The futile attempt to shut out death

    C. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    D. The mind's final escape at the moment of death

    Key: B (The futile attempt to shut out death)

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "The external world could take care of itself" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Prospero's indifference.

15. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all" (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three

sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The final sentence: personified triumph.

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Masque of the Red Death”? The sealed abbey with welded gates is a world of artificial pleasure built to deny death.

    A. Setting

    B. Diction / vocabulary

    C. Simile

    D. Point of view

    Key: A (Setting)

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14).

    Sample answer: Prospero declares that "the external world could take care of itself," but the clock forces even his musicians "to pause ... to harken to the sound," and the final sentence gives "the Red Death" "illimitable dominion over all."

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how privilege and isolation develops from an earlier story to “The Masque of the Red Death”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Prospero's withdrawal is selfish and doomed.

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Masque of the Red Death”? Seven rooms running east to west (blue to black) are often read as the stages of life; the last, black with blood-red windows, contains the clock.

    A. Metaphor

    B. Allusion

    C. Symbolism

    D. Point of view

    Key: C (Symbolism)

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “And Darkness and Decay and the Red Death held illimitable dominion over all” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 14) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The final sentence: personified triumph.

21. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “the musicians of the orchestra were constrained to pause, momentarily, in their performance, to harken to the sound” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 5). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The clock's power.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The story's setting and symbols show that wealth cannot protect anyone from death.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Prospero declares that "the external world could take care of itself," but the clock forces even his musicians "to pause ... to harken to the sound," and the final sentence gives "the Red Death" "illimitable dominion over all."

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “The external world could take care of itself” (The Masque of the Red Death, paragraph 2) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Prospero's indifference.

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Here the case was very different; as might have been expected from the duke's love of the bizarre.”, what does “bizarre” most nearly mean?

    A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    C. capture; being taken by force

    D. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

    Key: B (conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And one by one dropped the revellers in the blood-bedewed halls of their revel, and died each in the despairing posture of his fall.”, what does “bedewed” most nearly mean?

    A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    B. capture; being taken by force

    C. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    D. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

    Key: A (wet with drops, as of dew or tears)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “His vesture was dabbled in blood—and his broad brow, with all the features of the face, was besprinkled with the scarlet horror.”, what does “dabbled” most nearly mean?

    A. capture; being taken by force

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    C. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

    D. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    Key: C (dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid)

27. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “And the whole seizure, progress and termination of the disease, were the incidents of half an hour.”, what does “seizure” most nearly mean?

    A. wet with drops, as of dew or tears

    B. conspicuously or grossly unconventional or unusual

    C. capture; being taken by force

    D. dip a foot or hand briefly into a liquid

    Key: C (capture; being taken by force)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 12, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 3, 12, 11, 8, 5, 4, 1, 10, 6, 9, 13, 15, 14, 17, 16, 19, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	11, 8, 4, 6, 3, 12, 2, 7, 5, 10, 15, 13, 14, 21, 19, 16, 22, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	3, 7, 8, 10, 6, 2, 5, 1, 4, 14, 15, 13, 17, 19, 21, 16, 23, 22	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 10, 8, 11, 2, 9, 7, 4, 13, 15, 14, 21, 16, 17, 19, 22, 23, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3

AP	7, 24, 1, 25, 4, 6, 10, 15, 14, 13, 17, 16, 21, 19, 23, 20, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	26, 3, 12, 10, 11, 7, 9, 15, 13, 14, 19, 21, 17, 16, 23, 18, 20, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	24, 1, 25, 12, 2, 6, 27, 15, 13, 14, 17, 21, 19, 16, 23, 22, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	24, 11, 12, 4, 1, 26, 3, 14, 15, 13, 17, 19, 21, 16, 22, 23, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	9, 27, 11, 1, 12, 25, 5, 14, 15, 13, 19, 21, 16, 17, 23, 18, 20, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	3, 5, 25, 4, 1, 24, 12, 15, 13, 14, 17, 19, 21, 16, 18, 20, 22, 23	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Masque of the Red Death: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Edgar Allan Poe develops the inevitability of death across The Masque of the Red Death. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Masque of the Red Death and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to privilege and isolation.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Masque of the Red Death. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Masque of the Red Death finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of time. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: The inevitability of death

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Masque of the Red Death teaches about the inevitability of death. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the inevitability of death across The Masque of the Red Death. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the inevitability of death. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Masque of the Red Death (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the inevitability of death, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Masque of the Red Death's treatment of the inevitability of death in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging at

least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the inevitability of death in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Privilege and isolation

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Masque of the Red Death teaches about privilege and isolation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops privilege and isolation across The Masque of the Red Death. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of privilege and isolation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Masque of the Red Death (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of privilege and isolation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Masque of the Red Death's treatment of privilege and isolation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on privilege and isolation in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Time

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Masque of the Red Death teaches about time. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops time in The Masque of the Red Death. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops time across The Masque of the Red Death. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Masque of the Red Death (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of time. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of time in The Masque of the Red Death. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Masque of the Red Death (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of time, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Masque of the Red Death's treatment of time in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on time in The Masque of the Red Death that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on time in The Masque of the Red Death. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about time in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on time in The Masque of the Red Death, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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